

## Mav and the Shakespearian Shambles

Maverick woke up to something he hadn't experienced in months: silence. He looked at his nightstand. The sticky, syrup-stained Professor Bucktooth doll was gone. Apparently, a traveling puppet troupe—"The Felt-Bottom Players"—had swept through the neighborhood at dawn, and seeing a realistic, slightly damp beaver doll lying on the porch, they had assumed it was a prop and tossed it into their trunk.

"He's gone," Mav whispered, a slow grin spreading across his face. "No Beaver Justice. No structural audits. No lawsuits."

Maverick decided to have the **Best Day Ever**. He spent the morning dancing in a light Clovis drizzle, splashing in puddles without anyone telling him his splash-radius was "hydraulically offensive." He walked to the town square and solemnly gave a dollar to a charity for "Retired Circus Gerbils." Finally, he set up a small blanket in the park for a solo cheese-tasting session, enjoying a delicate Brie without a ghost-beaver screaming about its "low load-bearing density."

Life was perfect. Until he heard a familiar, high-pitched squawk coming from the park's amphitheater.

A puppet show was in full swing. A sign out front read: "**ROMEO AND JULIET: A TALE OF TWO STITCHES (LATE VALENTINE'S SPECIAL)**." Maverick sat on the grass, curious. On stage, a puppet Romeo was wooing a puppet Juliet on a cardboard balcony. Suddenly, the "Romeo" puppet was shoved aside by a very disoriented, very fuzzy beaver doll.

"Where am I?!" the Bucktooth doll shrieked, looking at the painted backdrop. "Is this Verona? The structural integrity of this balcony is appalling! It's held up by duct tape and prayer!"

The puppeteer, thinking this was a hilarious improv bit, went with it. He moved Juliet closer. "Oh, gentle Beaver! Why dost thou interrupt my sorrow?"

Bucktooth blinked his button eyes, still half-asleep and fully delusional. "Sorrows? I'll give you sorrows! This Romeo character has the charisma of a damp cedar plank! He wouldn't know a foundational pillar if it bit him on the tail!"

The Professor suddenly grew very solemn. He adjusted his felt tail and leaned toward the Juliet puppet. "Juliet, forget the Montague boy. He lives in a house with substandard plumbing. Come with me, and I shall build you a lodge that can withstand a Category 5 hurricane! Thy seams are exquisite, and thy stuffing is... divine."

Mav, watching from the third row, couldn't hold it in anymore. The sight of his "Chucky-beaver" friend trying to romance a felt puppet was too much. He let out a loud, honking laugh that echoed through the park.

The Bucktooth doll froze. He looked out into the crowd and spotted Maverick.

"Maverick?!" the doll screamed, suddenly realizing he was being manipulated by a man behind a curtain. "I'm a prop?! I'm a theatrical device?! This is a violation of my civil rights as a licensed ghost-engineer!"

The Professor snapped. He turned around and bit the nose of the Romeo puppet. He then began tearing down the cardboard balcony, shrieking about "building code violations." He grabbed a bucket of popcorn from the front row and began flicking kernels at the audience like tiny, buttery missiles.

"AHA! THE STAGE IS COLLAPSING! RUN FOR YOUR LIVES, YOU ROMANTIC AMATEURS!"

"Professor, stop!" Mav yelled, laughing so hard he was rolling on the grass.

"I HAD DREAMS, MAVERICK!" Bucktooth yelled, leaping from the stage and scuttling toward him. "I WAS GOING TO BE THE NEXT MOSS-COVERED MERYL STEEP! I HAD THE RANGE!"

The beaver doll chased Maverick across the park, snapping his felt jaws and throwing bits of stage-glitter. They sprinted through the gardens, Mav howling with laughter, until they both tripped over a decorative sprinkler and landed squarely in a massive, fragrant bed of Valentine's roses.

Mav sat up, covered in petals and thorns, and looked at the soggy beaver doll next to him. The Professor looked back, his button eyes wide. After a moment of silence, they both burst into a fit of hysterical, breathless laughter.

"You're a terrible actor, Professor," Mav wheezed.

"The Juliet puppet had no chemistry, Maverick. Her heart was literally made of cotton," the doll squeaked.

As they walked home, wet and smelling of roses, they left behind a devastated puppet troupe and a very confused audience. But for Mav and the Professor, it was the perfect ending to a very dramatic day.

"Toodaloo!" echoed through the neighborhood as they headed back to the safety of a house with (mostly) sound structure.